used all that much. It was somewhere you could go out with a ball and practice on your own. The day before the Colombia game, I bought some batteries and took this big portable stereo unit out with me. I borrowed two bags of balls. It was a boiling hot afternoon, so I was just in shorts and a undershirt. I stuck the stereo down, put on Tupac, the American rap singer, turned it up full blast and then spent a couple of hours on my own, practicing free-kicks: putting a ball down and then bending it in to the corner of the goal, over and over again.

The day of the game was my mum's birthday and, before going into the stadium, we spoke on the phone:

'Score a goal for me.'

The free-kick against Colombia was my first goal for England. I suppose I should remember everything about it: the foul, the wall, the angle. But somehow, even at the moment itself, what it meant to me was more important than the goal itself. I knew it had a chance as soon as I struck it and I raced off towards the corner flag to celebrate. Graeme Le Saux tried to grab me round the waist and then Sol Campbell jumped on my back. I'd known Sol since we were twelve years old, training together at Tottenham. Right then, he knew as well as anybody how important this was for me. Even scoring, though, I couldn't just enjoy plain and simple. Part of me wanted to run over to the bench to Glenn Hoddle. *There you go. What did you make of that?*

It was a pity I didn't, because on the way to the dugout I might have remembered to do what I'd promised before the game: to go and hug Terry Byrne and Steve Slattery, the England masseurs, if I scored. Terry and Slatts had talked to me—and listened to me—through all the highs and lows so far. They'd been great company. The right company: they'd say what they thought, not just what they thought I wanted to hear. And they'd listen for as long as I had something to say. Terry has become a really close friend over the years. After the game, I was on the phone to everybody. I was so pleased at my own performance, that we'd won and that we were through to the next round. With that free-kick, I felt I'd proved a point as far as the manager was concerned.

But would I be in the team for the game against Argentina in the second round? I was still pretty confused about the manager's attitude towards me. We had another awkward episode before we left for Saint-Etienne. Sometimes Glenn wanted us to take a walk to loosen up in the afternoon, just in tracksuits and sneakers. This time, though, we got down to the training ground and he